Hiking Safety Checklist

General safety information, not medical advice or a substitute for training. In an emergency, call 911.

From the free guide at https://jaechung-glitch.github.io/bugout/guides/what-to-do-if-lost-in-the-woods/, which lists its sources. Updated November 12, 2026.

What to do when you’re lost

1. **Stop, think, observe, plan.** Panic makes people walk faster in the wrong direction. Drink some water, eat something, and take stock.
2. **Try to orient yourself.** Check your map, compass or GPS app. Look for trail markers, and backtrack carefully only if you're confident.
3. **Stay put if you're not sure.** Moving makes you harder to find. Leave only to find water, and return to the same spot.
4. **Call for help.** Call 911 if you have any signal. Give the trail name, landmarks and your coordinates. If a call won't connect, try texting 911. Then save your battery.
5. **Make yourself visible.** Move to the nearest open area. Spread bright clothing or gear where it can be seen from above.
6. **Signal in threes.** Three whistle blasts, three shouts or three flashes is the universal distress call. Repeat at intervals.
7. **Prepare for the night.** Shelter comes before food: get out of wind and off cold ground well before dark.

How not to get lost

- [ ] Leave a trip plan with someone: where you're going, your route and when you'll be back
- [ ] Carry a paper map and compass, and know how to use them
- [ ] Download offline maps before you lose signal

- [ ] Carry a whistle, a mirror and a headlamp
- [ ] Pack extra water, food and a warm layer, even on short hikes
- [ ] Bring a charged phone and a power bank
- [ ] Wear bright clothing
- [ ] Agree on a meet-up spot if your group gets separated
- [ ] Look back often so you'll recognize the trail on the way out

Tick items off on your iPhone. BugOut, the free offline survival app, lets you make your own checklists and keeps its guides on your phone with no signal.